

Trip.com Group (TCOM): Mgmt call takeaways: 1-2 qtrs to fully reflect business model transition; expects no impact on hotel take rate; Buy



Following China's State Administration of Market Regulation (SAMR)'s announcement that it has completed a 6-month anti-trust investigation into TCOM, charging the company Rmb5.179bn in one-off penalties fees (see SAMR's announcement on [Jul 25](#) and our report on [Jul 27](#)), the company hosted a conference call where senior management team (CEO Jane Sun, CFO Cindy Wang) provided more details about the 19 measures the company is implementing to rectify any anti-trust practices and discussed the related financial implication. **As previously stated, the company reiterated it fully accepts the regulator's decision and penalties imposed, and highlighted that the investigation is over without any further outstanding issues. We note, certain operational adjustments (e.g., discontinuation of the automated price adjustment assistant (自动调价助手) and exclusive partnership required for Premium category hotels (特牌酒店)) that the group has implemented were already reflected in their 2Q26 guidance.**

Although its transition to a new merchant tiered cooperation model (i.e., somewhat similar to Booking.com's base/preferred/preferred plus tiering program, optional add-ons booster, etc.) could have a modest operational and GMV impact in 2H26, they do not anticipate any meaningful hit to its effective hotel take rate which is not that much different from other China OTAs (i.e., TCOM at 9.2% vs. Meituan at 8.5% in FY25). They still believe their ability to stay competitive hinges more on the value proposition they offer to hotel partners vs. peers, i.e., predictable booking volume, exposure to premium/higher-spending users, reliable 24/7 customer services etc. As discussed in our prior report ([Jan 19](#)), both Meituan's and Alibaba's take rates in China's food delivery and e-commerce markets have remained relatively stable in the 2-3 years after the conclusion of their investigations back in 2021. In the OTA space, TCOM/Tongcheng have maintained their hotel take rates largely unchanged despite various attempts by new entrants to compete by undercutting prices (e.g., zero take rate by JD, originally 4.5% by Douyin). Similarly, outside of China, Booking.com's take rates were not much affected by regulators' legal disputes on its industry practices over the years.

From our discussion with investors earlier today, while many were pleased to see a removal of stock overhang after the conclusion of the 6-month investigation, there

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was also some pushback to our Buy call including (1) further downside earnings risk in 2H26 - other than the short-term impact from its transition to new hotel tiered model as mentioned above; China's hotel industry RevPar trend has softened from +3-4% yoy in Apr-May to -1% yoy in June and -6% mtd in July per STR data against less favorable base comparison, even though domestic air traffic showed a noticeable recovery from -6%/-7% in May/June to +3% mtd in July ([Exhibit 3](#)); (2) newsflow regarding potential increased competition from Meituan, Fliggy and other competitors which may make new attempts to grab GMV share; (3) limited scope for the stock to re-rate considering that China Consumer/Internet names' forward P/E multiples have contracted to 12-13x as of late. As laid out in [Exhibit 5](#), **we now forecast +8% revenue growth and -2% EBIT decline for TCOM in FY26E by assuming (1) steady +5% yoy revenue growth in 2H26E (vs. +17%/+5% in 1Q/2Q26) including -3% yoy domestic travel revenue decline, +4% yoy outbound travel revenue growth and +45-50% yoy growth from its Trip.com platform; (2) -3.1-3.2pts yoy EBIT margin decline taking into account -1pts dilution from unfavorable revenue mix shift toward loss-making Trip.com platform - even though Trip.com itself is expected to see narrower EBIT loss ratio. This is then be followed by +11% yoy revenue and +13% EBIT growth in FY27E. At the current share price, the stock is trading at 11.6x/10x FY26E/FY27E P/Es respectively, a deep 30+% discount to Booking.com's 17x/14x.** By way of sensitivity, every -10% reduction in domestic hotel GMV and -1pts cut in domestic hotel take rate would lower our FY26E EBIT forecasts by TCOM by -7% and -11% respectively. We also highlight its EBIT/earnings sensitivity to China revenue growth and Trip.com's EBIT margin assumptions ([Exhibit 1](#)).

Overall, investors are likely to view the outcome of the investigation with no major surprise considering TCOM had in January ceased operating the two practices that the regulator identified (i.e., exclusivity partnership required for hotels joining the "Premium Category" and "lowest price platforms" for all other hotels. While it may take 1-2 quarters for the impact of its business model transition to be fully reflected in its financials, we think valuation suggests the stock has already discounted much pessimism toward its long-term growth trajectory - this we remain confident about esp. given its solid execution so far with rapid expansion into the rest of Asia via Trip.com platform. Maintain Buy with revised estimates (FY26E-FY28E EPS cut 1-24%) and 12-month target prices of US\$70/HK\$545 (from US\$71/HK\$560) after factoring in the one-off penalty and latest industry travel trend.

Summary and key highlights of Q&As during the conference call:

1. With the delivery of SAMR decision, are regulatory risks fully behind TCOM?

The company views the conclusion of the SAMR investigation as an important milestone for TCOM's China domestic business practices. TCOM fully accepts the decision and will implement rectification measures in a timely and comprehensive manner. TCOM views this as an opportunity to further strengthen its governance framework and support long-term development of its online travel businesses. The company is also committed to creating long-term value for their business partners and users by fostering industry competition based on service quality and user experience. Like other leading technology and platform companies globally, they will work constructively with regulators while delivering value to shareholders, the industry and the society.

2. What will be the new program replacing the former tier-1&2 delegated

distribution programs? What could the impact on TCOM's ADR and take rate be?

As laid out from its 19 measures across 5 key areas, TCOM will adopt a new multi-tiered partnership framework with a new traffic allocation mechanism that promotes greater flexibility, transparency, and shared business growth. Under its G2 strategy (Globalization and Great quality), they will strive to build long-term value to hotel partners by helping them to reach a broad base of high-quality leisure/business travelers and driving incremental demand across multiple travel scenarios such as inbound travel, the silver generation travel, as well as event-driven travels. The company expects its ADR to remain primarily driven by market supply and demand, and does not anticipate these measures to fundamentally change such dynamic. Similarly, its take rate should not see any structural changes, but may experience normal fluctuations driven by product mix, promotional activities and partner incentive programs.

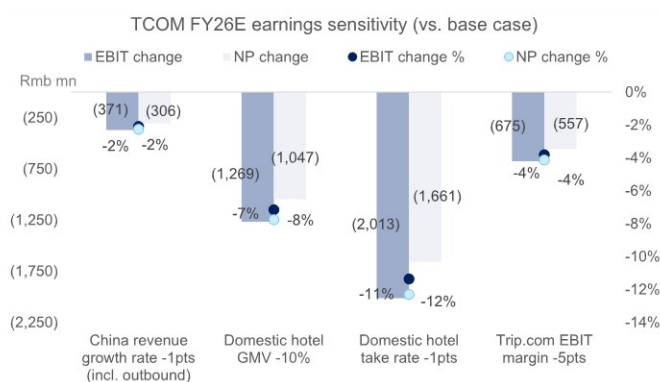
3. Which operations adjustments were already factored in 2Q26 guidance and what additional financial impact should investors expect in the coming quarters?

The company had discontinued its “automated price adjustment assistant” (自动调价助手) in Mar and the impact was already reflected in its 2Q26 guidance/outlook. Meanwhile, the discontinuation of tier-1&2 delegated distribution programs, alongside other transition progress, may introduce performance fluctuations in the coming quarters. Coupled with ongoing macroeconomic uncertainties, the company's visibility for 2H26 remains limited for now.

4. What is the financial impact of the penalty, and will it affect TCOM's operations and capital allocations?

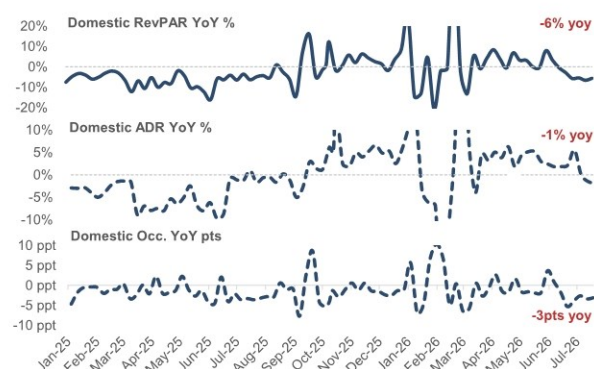
From an accounting perspective, TCOM will recognize a one-off expense of RMB5.179bn and a counter revenue of RMB122mn in 2Q26. Its capital allocations priorities remain unchanged. With the share price relatively depressed of late and the company's commitment to buybacks and commentary during 1Q earnings, we see an increased likelihood that the group has deployed some capital in share repurchases ytd.

Exhibit 1: TCOM FY26E earnings sensitivity to domestic business

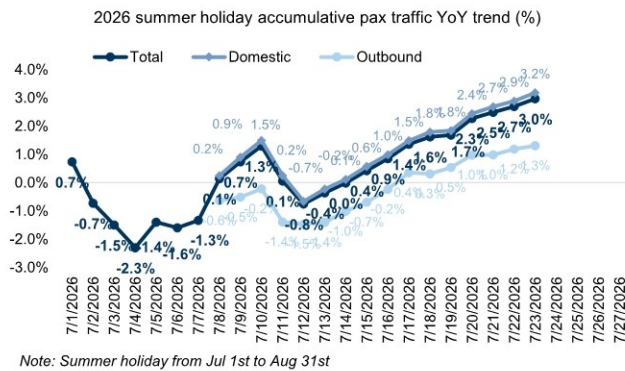


Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

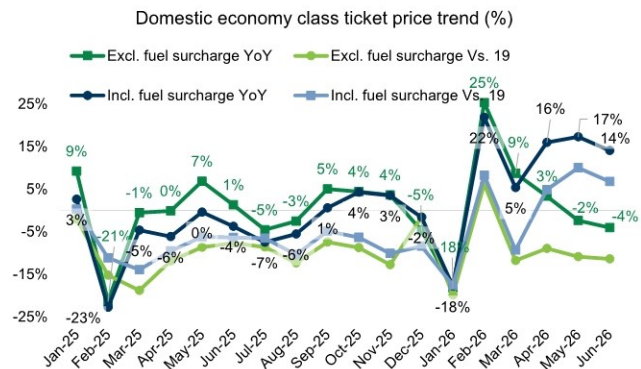
Exhibit 2: Domestic hotel RevPar weekly tracker



Source: STR, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 3: Summer holiday air traffic tracker

Source: DAST, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 4: Domestic economy class ticket price tracker

Source: DAST, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 5: Trip.com Group FY26E/FY27E forecast summary

Rmb mn	1Q26	2Q26E	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	2027E
Total net revenue	16,208	15,606	19,315	16,190	67,318	74,892
Domestic	9,824	9,248	11,559	9,283	39,914	42,356
Hotel	4,637	4,494	5,699	4,117	18,947	20,030
Transportation	2,372	1,563	1,820	1,512	7,266	7,236
Package tour and others	2,815	3,192	4,040	3,654	13,701	15,091
Outbound	2,436	2,291	2,865	2,247	9,839	10,846
Pure international	3,947	4,067	4,891	4,660	17,566	21,689
Trip.com	2,896	3,018	3,486	4,098	13,498	18,897
Skyscanner	1,051	1,049	1,405	562	4,068	2,792
YoY %						
Total revenue	17%	5%	5%	5%	8%	11%
Domestic	10%	-2%	-3%	-3%	1%	6%
Hotel	12%	4%	2%	1%	5%	6%
Transportation	-5%	-28%	-28%	-27%	-21%	0%
Package tour and others	23%	8%	7%	8%	12%	10%
Outbound	15%	4%	4%	4%	7%	10%
Pure international	42%	27%	31%	26%	28%	23%
Trip.com	65%	45%	45%	49%	50%	40%
EBIT (non-GAAP)	4,636	4,379	5,863	2,847	17,725	20,073
yoy	15%	-6%	-4%	-11%	-2%	13%
EBIT margin	28.6%	28.1%	30.4%	17.6%	26.3%	26.8%
margin yoy	-0.6ppt	-3.4ppt	-3.1ppt	-3.2ppt	-2.6ppt	0.5ppt
Net income (non-GAAP)	3,905	319	5,821	3,456	13,501	19,977
yoy	-7%	-94%	n.m.	-1%	n.m.	48%
EPS (HK\$)					20.1	29.7
EPS (US\$)					3.0	4.4
9961.HK share price (HK\$)					355.6	
TCOM share price (US\$)					44.9	
9961.HK P/E					11.7	10.1
TCOM P/E					11.6	10.0

Priced as of Jul 27, 2026/Jul 24, 2026 for the ADR.

Source: Datastream, Company data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Price Target Risks and Methodology – Trip.com Group

Valuation methodology: We have a Buy rating on Trip.com (TCOM/9961.HK) with 12-month target prices of US\$70/HK\$545 based on a SOTP, with the core travel business valued at a 16x P/E FY26E and affiliates valued based on their GS 12m target

prices or current market cap.

Key downside risks: Regulatory risk given its dominance in the China OTA industry, greater-than-expected competition, a slower-than-expected outbound traffic recovery.

TCOM	12m Price Target: \$70.00	Price: \$44.77	Upside: 56.4%
9961.HK	12m Price Target: HK\$545.00	Price: HK\$355.60	Upside: 53.3%

Buy		GS Forecast				
Market cap: \$28.5bn Enterprise value: \$23.9bn 3m ADTV: \$147.3mn China Asia Leisure M&A Rank: 3 Leases incl. in net debt & EV?: Yes			12/25	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E
		Revenue (Rmb mn) New	62,409.0	67,318.3	74,892.0	83,356.1
		Revenue (Rmb mn) Old	62,409.0	67,887.0	76,957.3	86,371.0
		EBITDA (Rmb mn)	18,888.0	18,554.5	20,958.8	23,791.3
		EPS (Rmb) New	45.59	20.08	30.64	35.73
		EPS (Rmb) Old	45.59	26.44	30.84	36.04
		P/E (X)	10.4	15.1	9.9	8.5
		P/B (X)	1.9	1.1	1.0	0.9
		Dividend yield (%)	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
		CROCI (%)	50.1	31.2	48.1	58.0
			3/26	6/26E	9/26E	12/26E
		EPS (Rmb)	5.73	0.47	8.54	5.14

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 27 Jul 2026 close.

Disclosure Appendix

Reg AC

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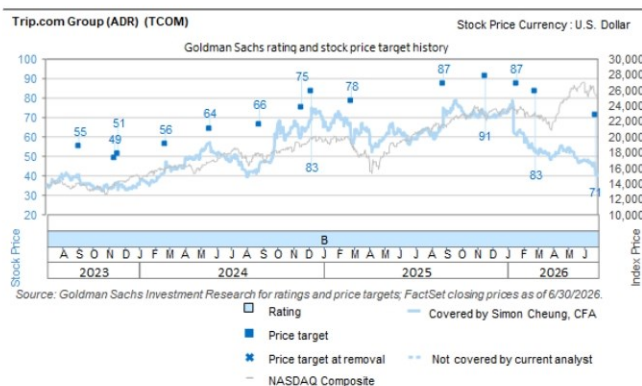
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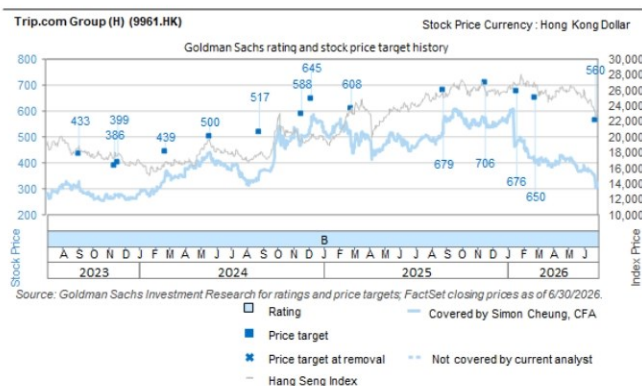
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	Buy	Hold	Sell		Buy	Hold	Sell
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Target price history table(s)

Trip.com Group (ADR) (TCOM)

Date of report	Target price (\$)	Closing price (\$)
27-Jul-26	70.00	44.77
25-Jun-26	71.00	40.49
26-Feb-26	83.00	52.27
19-Jan-26	87.00	61.77
18-Nov-25	91.00	72.44
28-Aug-25	87.00	75.03
25-Feb-25	78.00	57.30
08-Dec-24	83.00	69.07
19-Nov-24	75.00	62.74
27-Aug-24	66.00	45.97
21-May-24	64.00	55.83
22-Feb-24	56.00	44.67
21-Nov-23	51.00	32.78
14-Nov-23	49.00	35.36
05-Sep-23	55.00	38.26

Trip.com Group (H) (9961.HK)

Date of report	Target price (HK\$)	Closing price (HK\$)
27-Jul-26	545.00	355.60
25-Jun-26	560.00	315.00
26-Feb-26	650.00	400.40
19-Jan-26	676.00	470.40
18-Nov-25	706.00	564.50
28-Aug-25	679.00	552.00
25-Feb-25	608.00	462.00
08-Dec-24	645.00	542.00
19-Nov-24	588.00	506.00
27-Aug-24	517.00	366.40
21-May-24	500.00	440.00
22-Feb-24	439.00	355.60
21-Nov-23	399.00	275.60
14-Nov-23	386.00	272.00
05-Sep-23	433.00	304.00

Price targets shown in table(s) are unadjusted for corporate actions.

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